

## A series of delays

Even though the GIPR rolled out its train first, the East Indian Railway (EIR) was the frontrunner in terms of construction. By the end of 1853, it had completed 61 km of track. The inaugural run in the east was, however, delayed due to several factors. The line went through French-occupied Chandernagore and it took a while to settle disputes with the French and ultimately acquire permissions. To make matters worse, the ship HMS *Goodwin*, carrying the carriages for the EIR sank at Sandheads near Diamond Harbour off the Bay of Bengal. John Hodgson, EIR locomotive chief engineer remained unfazed and built the carriages locally with the help of coach-building firms Messrs Steward and Company and Seton and Company.

Although, the problem of the carriages was solved, the ship bringing the locomotive lost its way towards Australia and reached Calcutta in 1854, aboard the HMS *Dekagree*. Had it not been for these events, the story of the first train in India would have arguably been completely different.



▲ An illustration of the ship carrying the carriages sinking at Sandheads.